

Seawall height in Marathon

The elevation your city requires, the datum it is measured in, and the section of code that says so.

MARATHON • MONROE COUNTY

No minimum set in local code

Marathon's Land Development Regulations set no minimum or maximum seawall top elevation in any datum. The city fixes a two-foot cap width and a six-inch retention swale, berm or curb behind the wall, but the height comes from your engineer's design and your permits.

The detail

NO FIXED ELEVATION	Marathon LDR Sec. 106.36(H), Hardened Shorelines, sets the rules for bulkheads and seawalls and states no top elevation in NAVD88, NGVD29 or any other datum.
WHEN A WALL IS ALLOWED	Only on residential canals and altered shorelines, and only where riprap or sloping rock revetments with biotechnical erosion control will not suffice, as determined by the City Biologist. Sec. 106.36(H).
REPLACEMENT OR SEVERE EROSION	Allowed when replacing an existing deteriorated bulkhead or seawall, or to stabilize a severely eroded shoreline where riprap is shown not to be sufficient. Sec. 106.36(H)(1).
CAP WIDTH	Seawalls may have a cap of two feet in width. Sec. 106.36(H)(1).
RETENTION BEHIND THE WALL	The design must include a minimum six-inch retention swale, berm or curb directly landward of the wall. Sec. 106.36(H)(5).
WALL LINE	The bulkhead line is set at the property's average mean high water line when the permit is requested, and reclaiming eroded land by bulkheading and backfilling is prohibited. Sec. 106.36(H)(6).
NO OPEN WATER	No new vertical seawalls or bulkheads on open water shorelines, and none on or waterward of a sea turtle nesting beach. Sec. 106.36(H)(3) and (H)(4).
ENGINEER REQUIRED	All waterfront construction such as docks, piers, seawalls or revetments shall be planned and designed by a professional engineer. Sec. 104.64(B)(16).
V ZONES	In coastal high hazard areas, bulkheads and seawalls need other-agency authorization, must stand clear of buildings, and need a design professional's analysis showing no harmful

Where this comes from: City of Marathon Code, Appendix A Land Development Regulations, Sec. 106.36(H) Hardened Shorelines; also Secs. 106.38(F), 104.64(B)(16), 107.102.11(E)(1), 108.20(B)

Verified: 2026-10. Rules change — check the date above against today.

Before you call a contractor

1 Know your datum

A height means nothing without the datum it is measured from. NAVD88 and MLW are different reference points and the same wall gives different numbers in each. Ask which one any quoted elevation refers to.

2 Get the existing elevation surveyed

You cannot tell whether a wall meets the requirement by looking at it. A surveyor shooting the top of the cap settles it in an hour.

3 Ask what triggers the requirement

Most cities only apply the minimum to new walls or to substantial repair. What counts as substantial is defined differently in each city, and it is usually a percentage of length or of cost.

4 Ask about building higher now

Several cities require a wall built below the final figure to be engineered so it can be raised later. Doing it once is cheaper than doing it twice.